

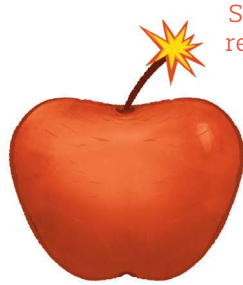
MANDAR DEODHAR

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Anand Dighe. And these hoardings adorn bus stops on arterial roads all across Mumbai, the city that Thackeray Sr could play like a Paganini played his violin: at will. For decades since 1989, when their Hindutva partnership began, the Sena had been the undisputed Big Brother to the BJP in these parts. Thackeray passed on in 2012, and **Narendra Modi** arrived in 2014—the centre of gravity was bound to shift. The 2022 split in the Sena only put the seal on that. Shinde has all along justified his turn to a satellite existence by claiming to be the rightful inheritor of the Sena legacy. The BJP is equally intent on demolishing **Uddhav Thackeray**'s proprietary claim over the Sena. But this piece of visual allegory, confirming who's the boss in the Mahayuti alliance, squeezes Thackeray Sr into an inconspicuous ring in the upper left hand corner. A picture is often worth a thousand silences.

▶ HIMACHAL PRADESH

The Forbidding Fruit



The disturbed snow cycle, the price of imported urea, cheaper imports from the South Asian neighbourhood—the whole world, it would appear, has been conspiring against the apple farmers of Himachal Pradesh. And contestants across party lines are feeling the heat. If Bollyqueen Kangana Ranaut is copping it in Mandi, former Union minister Anand Sharma—who first entered the Rajya Sabha all of four decades ago but is facing his first Lok Sabha election—is going a bit red in the face in Kangra. The social media was flooded with a communique he sent to the state government as India's commerce minister back in 2011, citing the WTO agreement to say hiking import duty beyond 50 per cent wasn't going to happen. Apple had bitten the BJP pretty bad during the assembly polls, and the Congress was gleefully pointing fingers at New Delhi even now. Till things turned vinegary with Sharma and his tariff recipes.

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

NO RETURN GIFTS

From amanuensis to would-be nemesis: **Dinesh Pratap Singh** managed that role reversal against **Sonia Gandhi**, wangling 38 per cent votes against her from Rae Bareli in 2019. The BJP has lobbed him one more moment in reflected spotlight, against RaGa this time. But that also turned the knob off on a parallel subplot cooking since the Rajya Sabha election in February. Manoj Pandey, one among



the eight Samajwadi Party MLAs who cross-voted in favour of the BJP, had fancied his chances from Rae Bareli and even met BJP big daddies in Delhi. Three more—Rakesh Pratap Singh, Vinod Chaturvedi and Puja Pal—were hopeful of a return gift, in the shape of a ticket. Alas, that wasn't to be. The four quislings had made their Faustian deals on the cheap. All their blandishments were to no avail. Pandey & Co have to chew their paan stoically till 2027 now.